“Nadiya, wake up.” Rose’s voice cut through the silence. She turned to her sister. “Check her pulse.”

Léa felt for a beat on Nadiya’s wrist. She found a faint one. She reached for the knife and cut the umbilical cord, thinking that might help. But the blood continued to flow, pooling on the floor. She got up and touched Nadiya’s face, her skin clammy and cold.

“Hold on. Breathe. You’re going to be fine. Open your eyes.” She checked the pulse at her wrist. Nothing. She checked the other wrist and the world slowed to a halt. “Please, Nadiya,” Léa whispered. “Please open your eyes.” But Nadiya was perfectly still, all color gone from her flesh.

“Oh, Léa.” Rose swallowed. “How did—?”

“She lost too much blood.” Léa’s breath was ragged. A death and a birth in a single moment. She closed her eyes as the baby’s first cry pierced the stillness, breaking her heart.

“It’s not your fault,” Rose said, reaching out to comfort her sister.

Léa began to cry. It was her fault. Nadiya should be singing to her baby, rocking her in her arms. If only Josef had been here, he would have saved her.

“It’s all right, Léa,” said Rose. “The baby is safe. You did the best you could.”

Léa wiped her eyes. Nadiya’s death felt like a portent of what was to come. All the hope she’d carried for the future dissolved. “We’re destined for the same fate, aren’t we?” she whispered.

“No. We’re going back to France,” Rose insisted.

Léa turned to her sister. “No one is coming to save us. We’ll never get out of here. The train lines have been bombed to bits, and any still functioning will soon be destroyed. There’s no way for us to get to France. We’re going to die here like Nadiya.”

“We will save ourselves,” Rose said, her voice strong. We’ll find a way out. I have a plan.”

Léa’s heart ached to hear her sister speak like that. She wished she could be the one consoling Rose. For two and a half years, she’d hoped for the war’s end, but now its approach filled her with dread.

The baby cried.

“Hush, little one,” Rose whispered. “You’re safe.” She looked at Léa. “What will we call her?”